

Call For Technology Experimentation: Transforming in Contact (EXTiC) 26-2

OPEN CALL for TECHNOLOGY

United States Central Command (CENTCOM), in partnership with the Defense Innovation Unit, is initiating an open call to find, vet, validate, and integrate new and emerging technologies in alignment with CENTCOM's strategic technology priority areas. Experimentation: Transforming in Contact (EXTiC) 26-2 provides relevant scenarios to Joint Command participants as they seek to establish an operationally relevant environment for new technologies and design cost-effective, repeatable experimentation events relevant to the future of warfare. In accordance with 10 U.S.C. 3458, technologies assessed through the competitive procedures used in this Open Call conform to the competition requirements of 10 U.S.C. 4021, 10 U.S.C. 4022, 10 U.S.C. 4023, FAR Part 35, and DFARS Subpart 212.70, and may be considered readily available to be observed, selected, negotiated, and awarded by federal government activities without further competition.

The Government is not liable for payment of any costs incurred in response to this Call for Technology (CFT) and participation in the EXTiC experimentation event and is under no obligation to act in any way on the information received or make any awards from this event. No costs incurred by interested companies / technologies in response to this announcement will be reimbursed. The information provided may be used by any federal agency in developing a future acquisition strategy, Performance Work Statement (PWS), Statement of Objectives (SOO) and / or Performance Based Specifications (PBSs). Interested parties are responsible for adequately marking proprietary or competition-sensitive information contained in their response.

Submissions will be assessed by a peer panel which may include DoW and supporting industry and academic Subject Matter Experts (SMEs) that will determine the technical merit of submissions based on maturity and mission threat alignment. If a submission is deemed "awardable" it may be eligible for award of further research, prototyping, procurement for experimental purposes, and even production under 10 USC 4021, 10 USC 4022, 10 USC 3458, FAR/DFARS Part 35, and DFARS Subpart 212.70, and 10 USC 4023.

PURPOSE:

Find, vet, validate, and integrate new and emerging technologies into EXTiC 26-2 in alignment with CENTCOM's strategic technology priority areas. This experimentation event provides relevant scenarios to Joint Command participants as they seek to establish an operationally relevant environment for new technologies and design cost-effective, repeatable experimentation events relevant to the future of warfare.

BACKGROUND:

Department of War (DoW) experimentation events are vital for advancing military capabilities and ensuring strategic readiness. These events enable the validation of emerging technologies and innovative concepts and enhance operational effectiveness and preparedness. The mission of the Defense Innovation OnRamp Hub: Arizona's EXTiC program is to provide the DoW with a structured, repeatable venue for rapidly integrating, testing, and assessing emerging technologies alongside Warfighters in operationally relevant environments. EXTiC events accelerate the transition of capabilities from concept to the field, ensuring that technology serves the mission and strengthens the Joint Force's readiness for future conflict.

INFORMATION REQUESTED:

To support the development of an operationally coherent mission thread for EXTiC 26-2, the Government is seeking technologies that can be integrated, stressed, and evaluated across the verticals outlined below. The intent is not to showcase isolated systems, but to identify capabilities that can function inside a realistic, contested environment where detection, custody, adversarial pressure, Command and Control (C2) integration, and resilience are exercised end-to-end.

Organizations with technologies that align to one or more of these verticals are invited to submit a structured package for review. The submission consists of **two (2)** components:

1. **Whitepaper (10 pages maximum).** Provide a brief overview of the technology's development path, operational or test history, and current technology readiness level (TRL). Identify the EXTiC vertical(s) the capability supports and clearly state the role it would play within the mission thread.
2. **Technology Quad Chart (One (1) page).** Summarize the capability, prior integration or deployment, and current TRL. Include a technical point of contact with complete point of contact (POC) and communication details.

Technologies that demonstrate sufficient maturity and mission-thread alignment may be selected for integration and participation in EXTiC 26-2 from 27-29 July 2026.

TECHNOLOGY FOCUS AREAS:

Together, the first four verticals (see below) form a cohesive operational construct that represents the progression from detection to identification to contested threat pressure to sensor-to-shooter integration. The fifth vertical addresses continued functionality, across the entire operational construct, in severely degraded environments.

1. **Detection and Early Warning (Detection):** This vertical establishes the foundational tripwire for the entire EXTiC mission thread. CENTCOM regularly encounters low-flying, Small Unmanned Aircraft System (sUAS) launched by proxy actors who use terrain, urban structures, and low-radar cross section (RCS) profiles to exploit radar blind spots. The

Detection & Early Warning vertical deploys a layered sensing architecture to surface inbound systems that would otherwise remain hidden. These sensing modalities reflect the real-world constraints at CENTCOM outposts and form the essential first step in the detect-track-defeat kill chain. Key Elements are:

- a. wide-area sensing of terrain-masked, low-altitude sUAS.
 - b. multi-modality detection.
 - c. early-tripwire activation before threats breach radar line-of-sight.
 - d. sensor grid designed to fill the “non-radar” gaps CENTCOM faces at austere sites.
 - e. multi-spectrum sensors that can detect fiber/tethered sUAS threats.
2. **ISR and Target Custody (Integration):** Once a detection event occurs, airborne intelligence, surveillance, and reconnaissance (ISR) provides positive identification (PID) and persistent tracking of the threat through maneuver and terrain masking. This vertical demonstrates how UAS can remain operational in contested electromagnetic conditions through resilient navigation and autonomous mapping capabilities. ISR becomes the stabilizing element of the mission thread, carrying threat custody from initial detection to handoff. One potential example could be ISR assets seed droppable sensors along the threat axis, expanding the awareness bubble and enabling deeper, more resilient sensing around the defended location. Key elements are:
 - a. airborne ISR verifies, classifies, and maintains custody on threats.
 - b. UAS equipped with electro-optical/infrared (EO/IR), mapping, and signals-sensing payloads.
 - c. GPS-denied navigation (Alt/PNT) for continuity under electronic warfare (EW).
 - d. ISR aircraft deploy droppable sensors to extend the detection perimeter.
3. **Adversarial EW and Swarm Threat Emulation (Action):** This vertical introduces the contested conditions that distinguish an EXTiC event from a tech showcase. It replicates adversarial behaviors common to CENTCOM’s AOR and is designed to saturate sensors and overwhelm operators. This vertical intentionally imposes stress on every other part of the system. It is the realism driver, forcing the Blue kill chain to operate against pressure that mirrors real-world CENTCOM threat conditions. Key elements are:
 - a. realistic Red-force behavior (multi-axis swarms, FPV elements, and deception patterns).
 - b. adversarial radio frequency (RF) jamming and global position system (GPS) spoofing to stress Blue systems.
 - c. replication of Iranian proxy UAS tactics, techniques, and procedures (TTPs), layered threat profiles, and variable platforms to include fiber/tethered UAS.
 - d. large-scale swarm behavior to simulate saturation attacks.

4. **Integrated C2 and Defeat Layer (Communications):** This vertical merges command-and-control with the defeat architecture to complete the detect → decide → engage chain. All sensing and ISR inputs route through an open-architecture C2 system capable of ingesting heterogeneous data formats, generating fused tracks, automating cueing, and deconflicting multiple effectors. The Defeat Layer then engages validated threats using a mix of kinetic interceptors, directed energy (DE) systems, RF jammers, or interceptor drones. This vertical demonstrates whether a layered defense can actually defeat swarms, multi-axis, and fiber/tethered sUAS threats once exposed to the complexities introduced in the earlier verticals. It is the culminating demonstration of the event, where the entire EXTiC system proves its operational coherence. Key elements are:
 - a. open-architecture C2 system that provides an operational picture by integrating all sensor and ISR feeds.
 - b. unified common operating picture (COP) with automated threat cueing.
 - c. integration of kinetic and non-kinetic short range air defense (SHORAD) systems (1–5 km).
 - d. sensor → decision → shooter orchestration demonstrated end-to-end.
 - e. engagement accuracy tested under contested conditions.
5. **Resilience & Sustainment Layer (Expeditionary Power & Site Hardening):** This vertical ensures the entire system continues to operate when conditions shift from contested to degraded; the point where most architectures begin to fail. It focuses on the technologies that keep sensors alive, keep ISR flying, and keep C2 connected even when load, weather, interference, or deliberate adversarial effects erode performance. Some potential examples are hybrid power solutions to extend mission endurance; resilient Alt/PNT methods preserve flight paths and custody when GPS becomes unreliable; and mesh radios maintain C2 continuity when traditional links collapse. Autonomous fallback behaviors allow platforms to self-manage and hold position or return to mission without operator intervention. Technology and systems that protect and increase the survivability of equipment from adversarial sUAS strikes. Key elements are:
 - a. hybrid power solutions enabling extended UAS and sensor endurance.
 - b. Alt/PNT resilience to maintain operations through RF jamming and GPS degradation or spoofing.
 - c. mesh networking and redundant comms pathways to preserve C2.
 - d. autonomous fallback behaviors for continuity when links are contested.
 - e. system-level survivability under heat, dust, RF congestion, and signal denial.
 - f. netting, barriers, chains/cables, or other force protection to create stand-off and protect equipment from adversarial sUAS.

EXTiC 26-2 TECHNOLOGY SELECTION PHASES:

PHASE 1: Technology Selection

Technologies will be evaluated based on their alignment to the focus areas and the materials submitted. This phase includes a structured review to assess maturity, relevance, and integration potential. Submissions that were determined to have merit for technologies areas identified will receive a notification to participate in Phase 2.

PHASE 2: Technical Demonstration

Selected vendors will receive a visit from a member of the technical assessment team and demonstrate the capabilities of their technology(s). The assessment team will determine if the readiness, interoperability, and mission relevance of the technology meets the threshold to participate in the experimentation event. Those technologies that are determined to meet the threshold for participation in Phase 3 will receive a notification to participate.

PHASE 3: Execution

The EXTiC 26-2 experiment event will take place on 27 July 2026. Technologies will be assessed against Independent Verification & Validation (IV&V) assessments worked with the company. This event will include scenario runs, daily coordination sessions, and a Distinguished Visitor Day on 29 July 2026. An After Action Review will occur on 30 July 2026.

PHASE 4: Evaluation and Reporting

Letters of Observation (LOOs) will be provided to those entities that participated in the experimentation event. No vendor proprietary information will be shared outside of government control.

In accordance with applicable statutory and regulatory authorities (10 U.S.C. 3458) Peer Panel assessors will provide written evaluations based on the criteria outlined in their invitations to participate in the experimentation event. The Government Selecting Official (GSO) may use these assessments to determine whether a solution is suitable for award or should advance toward an award. The Government may also elect not to proceed with any award while retaining the assessments for future consideration of the technologies' potential viability.

CONTRACTOR SUPPORT:

The Government may use contracted personnel to provide administrative assistance to federal employees regarding all aspects of any actions ensuing from this announcement, including the evaluation of white papers and subsequent proposals. Government support contractors will be bound by appropriate non-disclosure agreements (NDA) to protect proprietary and source-selection information and / or awarded contract(s) to provide the support outlined above. They are not permitted to release any source-selection information to third parties, including others in their

organization. By submission of a white paper, offerors are hereby granting support contractors access to financial, confidential, proprietary, and/or trade secret markings.

ORGANIZATIONAL CONFLICT of INTEREST (OCI) – Technology Demonstrators:

Respondents are participating solely as technology demonstrators and will not perform assessment, evaluation, scoring, or advisory functions related to other technologies to preserve the integrity, fairness, and objectivity of the event.

Responses to this CFT are to be UNCLASSIFIED or Controlled Unclassified Information (CUI), and are due NLT 1200 hrs. (MST), 5 May 2026, to the EXTiC Project Manager. The following link can be used for submissions:: [EXTiC 26-2 Intake Form](#).

The point of contact for this CFT is Nathan Cahoon, EXTiC Project Manager, Defense Innovation OnRamp Hub: Arizona, nate@swmac.org, Phone # 520-606-4784.